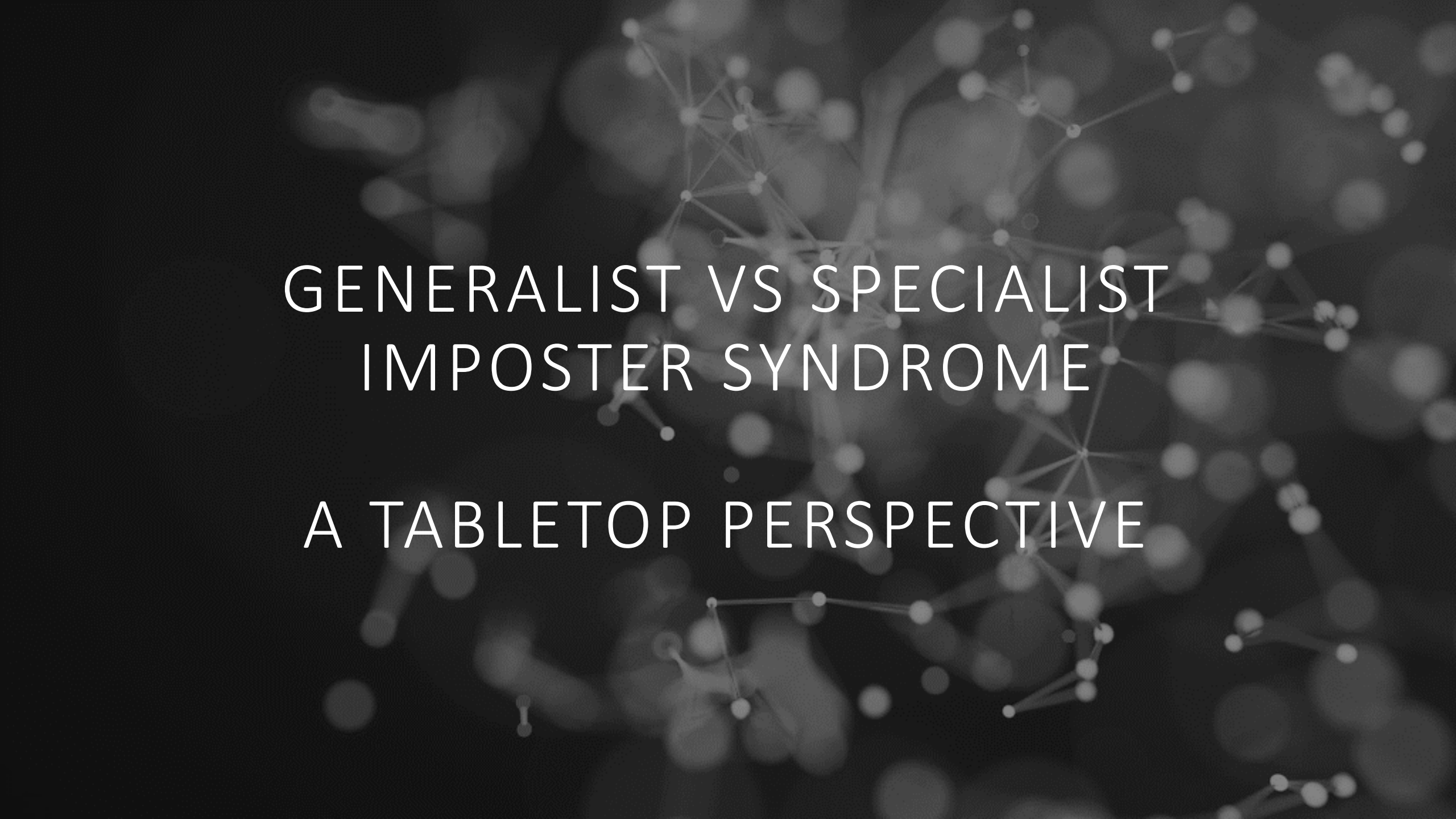




GENERALIST VS SPECIALIST IMPOSTER SYNDROME

A TABLETOP PERSPECTIVE



AGENDA

INTRODUCTIONS

DEFINITIONS & MYTHS

PROS & CONS

TABLETOP SCENARIOS

FINAL TIPS & TAKEAWAYS





JORDON DARLING

OWNER @ HITECH COMPUTER SOLUTIONS

OWNER @ HITECH SECURE

VP @ TOP DOG PC SERVICES

ADJUNCT FACULTY @ UNWSP

MCP, SBSC, MS, CISSP, CCP, CvCISO





DAVE TUCKMAN

EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR @ S2 ACADEMY

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COMPTIA, EC-COUNCIL, INFRAGARD

CvCISO, CCISO, CISM, CISSP, CDPSE, CEH, DTEF,
SEC+, MSx3, & MISC OTHERS



*“IMPOSTER SYNDROME ISN'T A
SIGNAL OF INCOMPETENCE.*

*IT'S OFTEN A SIDE EFFECT OF
GROWTH AND CARING ABOUT
THE QUALITY OF YOUR WORK.”*

DEFINITIONS + MYTHS

WHAT IS A GENERALIST?
WHAT IS A SPECIALIST?





CYBERSECURITY GENERALIST

- A professional with broad knowledge across multiple domains of security – such as GRC, incident response, network defense, cloud security, identity management, and more – without specializing deeply in just one area.
- **PROS** Versatile, strategic bridge-builder, great in small orgs / startups, fast learners, Broad, flexible, often cross-functional, connectors across silos
- **CONS** Prone to feeling “not enough,” lack of visible mastery, undervalued in technical orgs, risk of burnout
- **TRIGGERS FOR IMPOSTER SYNDROME**
 - “jack of all trades, master of none”
 - Being in a room with deep specialists and not speaking up
 - Job postings that list every tool under the sun





CYBERSECURITY SPECIALIST

- **A professional with deep expertise and advanced technical skill in a focused area of security, such as pen testing, malware reverse engineering, cloud security, identity and access management, or incident response. Deep, focused, often a go-to expert in one area**
- **PROS** Deeper knowledge = credibility, well-defined career track(s), respected in technical spaces
- **CONS** May struggle with context switching, more isolated work environment, communication challenges, risk of burnout
- **TRIGGERS FOR IMPOSTER SYNDROME**
 - Feeling irrelevant if their one specialty is no longer hot
 - Being asked to weigh in outside their expertise
 - Transitioning into management or broader roles





IMPOSTER SYNDROME

- The internal experience of believing that you're not as competent as others perceive you to be despite your skills, experience, and accomplishments
- Imposter syndrome ≠ low self-esteem
- Internalized fear of being exposed as a fraud.
- Common in **high performers**, especially those who've taken **non-linear paths** (like generalists).
- **TRIGGERS FOR IMPOSTER SYNDROME**
 - Comparing yourself to others (especially online)
 - Being “the first at something” (family, work, social circles, etc.)
 - Transition moments: new job, promotion, speaking gig (like this!)



TABLETOP SCENARIOS

SCENARIO 1: RANSOMWARE ATTACK ON CORE SYSTEMS

SITUATION:

A ransomware attack encrypts critical business systems, including customer databases and internal communication tools. A ransom note demands payment in cryptocurrency within 48 hours.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

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A ransomware attack encrypts critical business systems, including customer databases and internal communication tools. A ransom note demands payment in cryptocurrency within 48 hours.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

The responder initiates basic containment steps (disconnecting systems) but lacks deep knowledge of ransomware behavior or decryption options.

Rely heavily on external vendors and struggle to prioritize recovery steps.

SPECIALIST RESPONSE



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SPECIALIST RESPONSE

A cybersecurity incident response specialist quickly identifies the ransomware strain, isolates affected systems, checks for backups, and coordinates with legal and law enforcement.

They lead a structured recovery and communication plan.

TABLETOP SCENARIOS

SCENARIO 2: INSIDER THREAT – DATA EXFILTRATION

SITUATION:

An employee is suspected of downloading large volumes of sensitive data before resigning.
The activity was flagged by a DLP (Data Loss Prevention) system.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

SITUATION:

An employee is suspected of downloading large volumes of sensitive data before resigning.
The activity was flagged by a DLP (Data Loss Prevention) system.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

An insider threat analyst quickly reviews logs, correlates access patterns, and works with HR and legal to secure the employee's access and begins a forensic investigation.

SITUATION:

An employee is suspected of downloading large volumes of sensitive data before resigning.
The activity was flagged by a DLP (Data Loss Prevention) system.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

The responder is unsure how to interpret DLP logs or correlate them with user behavior.

This delays action while seeking help, risking further data loss.

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

An insider threat analyst quickly reviews logs, correlates access patterns, and works with HR and legal to secure the employee's access and begins a forensic investigation.

TABLETOP SCENARIOS

SCENARIO 3: CLOUD MISCONFIGURATION EXPOSURE

SITUATION:

A misconfigured cloud storage bucket exposes sensitive customer data to the public internet.
The issue is discovered by a third party and reported publicly.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

SITUATION:

A misconfigured cloud storage bucket exposes sensitive customer data to the public internet.
The issue is discovered by a third party and reported publicly.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

The responder lacks deep cloud security knowledge and struggles to understand the scope of exposure or how to remediate it quickly.

They may downplay the issue or delay disclosure.

SPECIALIST RESPONSE



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GENERALIST RESPONSE

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SPECIALIST RESPONSE

A cloud security engineer immediately identifies the misconfiguration, remediates access controls, assesses logs for access history, and coordinates breach notification.

TABLETOP SCENARIOS

SCENARIO 4: PHISHING CAMPAIGN COMPROMISE

SITUATION:

Multiple employees report suspicious emails.

One user clicks a link and enters credentials, leading to unauthorized access to internal systems.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

SITUATION:

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One user clicks a link and enters credentials, leading to unauthorized access to internal systems.

GENERALIST RESPONSE

SPECIALIST RESPONSE

An email security analyst traces the phishing campaign, identifies affected users, blocks malicious domains, and checks for signs of compromise across the network.

SITUATION:

Multiple employees report suspicious emails.

One user clicks a link and enters credentials, leading to unauthorized access to internal systems.

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The responder lacks deep cloud security knowledge and struggles to understand the scope of exposure or how to remediate it quickly.

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SPECIALIST RESPONSE

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FINAL TIPS & TAKEAWAYS

NAME IT

“This is imposter syndrome, not a signal I don’t belong.”

REFRAME IT

“I don’t know this yet” vs “I shouldn’t be here.”

DOCUMENT WINS

Create a personal “brag book” or folder of “thank yous”

CONNECT

You are not alone. Find your people.

FOR GENERALISTS

Practice describing your value in terms of *impact*, not just tools or certs.

Collect stories of situations where your range made the difference.

FOR SPECIALISTS

Recognize the value of saying “I don’t know” and collaborating across boundaries.



THANK YOU!

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